

Von Neumann HQ

Revise 360 lesson plan — 60 minutes

Unit	OCR J277 1.1 Systems architecture — Paper 1, Computer systems
Lesson	Von Neumann HQ (lesson 2 of the unit)
Lesson ID	sa-102
Experience ID	sa-102
Plan ID	PLAN-SA-L02
Content version	fd4c4d9b1698
Website	https://revise360.co.uk/experience.html?id=sa-102

Big question, outcomes and success criteria

Big question — What other architectures exist and where are they used?

Prerequisites

The lesson before this one is sa-101. Pupils should already have finished it: the starter below retrieves from it.

Assessable outcomes

1. **sa-102-o1** — describe the von Neumann architecture
2. **sa-102-o2** — know the components of the von Neumann architecture
3. **sa-102-o3** — understand what a keyword is

Vocabulary, resources and preparation

Key vocabulary — ALU, CU (control unit)

Resources

SLIDES	presentations/SA_L02_VonNeumannHQ_Lesson.pptx
WORKSHEET	worksheets/SA_L02_VonNeumannHQ_Worksheet.docx
ONLINE EXPERIENCE	experience.html?id=sa-102

Before the lesson

1. Sign in on the **teacher dashboard** (teacher.html) and open **Class logins**. Enter the class or group and the usernames, one per line, then print the login cards. A pupil cannot sign in without one, so do this before the lesson rather than in it.
2. Print the worksheet, one per pupil.
3. Open the slides and the experience once yourself, on the machine you will be teaching from, so the 360 image is already cached.
4. Check headsets or devices are charged and on the school network.

How pupils get in

1. Go to [topics.html](#) on revise360.co.uk.
2. Sign in with the **username and PIN from the login card**. The class is already set against the card.
3. Choose the topic, then this lesson's card.

Worth knowing before you promise anything. In this build APP_CONFIG.backendUrl is empty, so logins, login cards and progress are stored on the device the pupil used. The teacher dashboard says so too. A pupil who moves to a different machine starts again, so keep a class on the same devices within a unit, and treat the paper worksheet as the record that travels.

Teaching sequence

Sixty minutes including transitions. The online block is the one to move if your lesson is shorter: see the adaptation at the end.

MIN	PHASE	TEACHER	PUPILS	EVIDENCE TO CHECK
0-5	Retrieve	Starter on the board or the worksheet, from the last lesson and this lesson's prerequisites.	Answer the starter on the worksheet.	The starter box on SA_L02_VonNeumannHQ_Worksheet.docx is filled in.
5-8	Review the starter	Take answers; correct the one most got wrong.	Correct their own starter.	A correction written, not just a tick.
8-18	Explain and model	The new idea in two or three steps, with the example worked in front of the class.	Listen and answer questions about the example.	They can say why, not only what.
18-21	Set up and settle	Sign-in, launch, and what to write before anyone taps an answer.	Sign in, open the lesson, find John von Neumann.	Everyone is in and on station 1.
21-43	Online: work the stations in order	Pupils read each wall, write the key fact and the challenge, then answer at the badge.	Read each wall, write the key fact and the challenge, then answer at the badge.	The worksheet has writing on it for each of the 6 stations before the badge is tapped.
43-48	Check understanding	The hinge question, hands down.	Answer the hinge question, hands down.	The split across the options.
48-56	Apply	Exam practice on the worksheet, in silence.	Exam practice, in silence.	worksheet, Exam practice a) to c)
56-60	Exit and set up the next lesson	The exit question and the retrieval link to next lesson.	Write the exit answer.	One sentence that answers the big question.

The explanation and the worked example

This is what the walls of the experience say, station by station. Teach the first two or three from the front before anyone puts a headset on; the rest the pupils read for themselves.

1. John von Neumann

- A Hungarian-American mathematician and computer scientist.
- In 1945 he described a design for a computer that stores programs in memory.
- Nearly all modern computers still follow his ideas.

Challenge on this wall: Who was John von Neumann, and why is he important to computing?

2. The stored-program concept

- Instructions and data are both stored in the same main memory.
- The CPU fetches instructions and data from memory, one at a time.
- Loading a different program means the same computer can do a different job.

Challenge on this wall: Explain how data and instructions are stored in von Neumann architecture.

3. Program counter and accumulator

- Program counter (PC): holds the address of the next instruction to be fetched.
- It increments during each fetch-decode-execute cycle.
- Accumulator (ACC): holds the results of calculations done by the ALU.

Challenge on this wall: Explain the purpose of the program counter and how its value changes.

4. MAR and MDR

- MAR (memory address register): holds the address of the data or instruction to be fetched or stored.
- MDR (memory data register): holds the data or instruction fetched from memory, or to be written to it.
- They work as a pair to move data between the CPU and RAM.

Challenge on this wall: Describe the purpose of the memory data register.

5. Other architectures

- Harvard architecture stores instructions and data in separate memories, with separate buses.
- It lets an instruction and data be fetched at the same time.
- It's used in many embedded systems and microcontrollers.

Challenge on this wall: What other architectures exist, and where are they used?

6. Keywords

- Every programming language has keywords: reserved words with a special meaning.
- Python keywords include if, else, while, for, def, return, True and False.
- You can't use a keyword as a variable name.

Challenge on this wall: Find three Python keywords and write what each one does.

Retrieval and the check for understanding

Starter — The same laptop can run a game, then a word processor, then a browser, with no hardware changed. What makes that possible?

Answer space: 3 lines on the worksheet.

The answer is in the teacher answers for this unit, not on this plan: a plan left on a desk should not give it away.

Hinge question

Use this one, hands down, before anyone moves on to independent work. It is a real activity from the experience (sa-102-s4-c1), so the wording a pupil sees matches the wording you say.

Which register holds the address of data to be fetched from memory?

Correct: Memory address register (MAR)

What a pupil might choose instead

- Memory data register (MDR)
- Accumulator
- Program counter

Count the hands on each. If more than a few of the class are on one wrong option, that option is the misconception to teach against before anyone goes on: go back to the station this question sits on and work through its example again, aloud, before the independent work.

The course's own response to a wrong answer here: Address: MAR. Data: MDR.

One response, not four. one response covers every wrong option; it does not say what to revisit for each one, so decide your own reteach for each option before the lesson - the list above is the start of it.

Guided to independent practice

Recognise	13	The answer is on the screen and the pupil picks it: multiple choice, choosing several, matching a pair.
Construct	2	Nothing is offered. The pupil classifies, orders, fills in a table or works a number out, and types or places the answer.

Scaffolds already in the product, and how they fade

- **Hint** is a ladder, not a door: the first rung names the idea, the next shows the shape of the code, the next how it starts, the last animates the technique on different data. A pupil asks for each rung. None of them is the answer.
- **Run** is free and unmarked; **Check my answer** marks. A pupil may run as often as they like, which is what makes trial and error safe.
- **I need help** says to ask you, and says plainly that the question still has to be completed. It does not notify anyone and it does not unlock anything.
- The worked example appears on every early activity and on none of the late ones. That fade is deliberate; it is not a missing example.

Accessibility

- **Read aloud** on every task window reads the task and its brief, with the prescribed values read as values rather than as punctuation.
- Text is 16px or larger throughout, and a question window scrolls rather than shrinking its type.
- Prescribed data is boxed and in a monospace face as well as coloured, so it still reads as code in black and white, in a high-contrast mode, and to a pupil who does not separate green from amber.
- **Lower literacy and EAL:** pre-teach the vocabulary above; let the pupil say the key fact before writing it; accept the key fact in two or three words.
- **SEND:** the sequence is compulsory but the pace is not. A pupil may finish a station next lesson; the progress saves after every answer and reopens at their earliest unfinished question.
- A headset is never required. Every experience works on a laptop or a tablet with a mouse or a finger.

Delivering the online experience

Before anyone enters

- Worksheet out, pen in hand. The rule is write first, then answer at the badge: the first answer is the one that counts.
- Say where the stations are. They are numbered around the room: 1 and 2 to the right, 3 and 4 behind, 5 and 6 to the left, and the final challenge on the floor.
- Say that a badge marked **Not yet** is not a fault. It opens when the station they are on is finished.

The stations, and what to record at each

#	STATION	ACTIVITIES	RECORD ON PAPER
1	John von Neumann	2	John von Neumann was...
2	The stored-program concept	2	In von Neumann architecture, instructions and data are...
3	Program counter and accumulator	2	The PC... The accumulator...
4	MAR and MDR	2	The MAR holds... The MDR holds...
5	Other architectures	2	Another architecture is...
6	Keywords	3	A keyword is...
final	Final challenge: name that part	2	the answer to the station's challenge

Where to pause

Stop the class after station 2 and take answers to its challenge out loud. That is the point where a pupil who has misread the technique can still be put right cheaply.

Afterwards

Headsets off and down. Ask three pupils for the key fact from a station of your choosing, in their own words and not read off the sheet. Then the exit question.

Assessment, evidence and unfinished work

ID	QUESTION	MARKS	WHERE
sa-102-x1	Name the register that holds the address of the next instruction to be fetched.	1	worksheet, Exam practice a); deck, Exam practice slide
sa-102-x2	Describe what the memory data register holds and when it is used.	2	worksheet, Exam practice b); deck, Exam practice slide
sa-102-x3	Explain what happens during each of the three stages of the fetch-decode-execute cycle.	6	worksheet, Exam practice c); deck, Exam practice slide

Expected answers

Model answers and marking guidance are teacher-only and are not printed on this plan. They are in the unit's teacher guide pack, and the per-activity marking for this lesson is in `answers/records/sa-102.json`, which is not published with the website.

Common errors

The wrong options the activities offer are the errors this lesson expects. The commonest to watch for:

- **What is John von Neumann best known for in computing?** — Inventing the World Wide Web; Founding a games company
- **When did von Neumann describe his architecture?** — 1985; 2001
- **In von Neumann architecture, where are instructions stored?** — Only inside the ALU; In a separate memory from data
- **Why is the stored-program idea so useful?** — It makes computers use no power; It removes the need for a CPU
- **What does the program counter hold?** — The result of the last calculation; The current instruction's data

Unfinished work

Record where each pupil stopped, not a tick. They resume at their earliest unfinished question, and a station left half-done is the thing to open next lesson. Do not mark the lesson complete for a pupil who did not finish it: the score screen already shows what was and was not done, and that is the honest record.

Exit, next lesson and homework

Exit check

One of these, written, not a show of hands:

- The von Neumann architecture
- The PC, MAR, MDR and accumulator
- What a keyword is

The confidence columns on the worksheet are a supplement to this, not a substitute: a pupil who rates themselves confident and cannot answer the exit question has told you nothing.

Retrieval link to next lesson

Next is sa-103, Speed lab. Use this lesson's big question as next lesson's starter, so the first thing they do is retrieve it.

Homework

Finish any station left open, on the website, from the question they stopped at. If the class has no devices at home, set the exam practice on the worksheet instead and mark it next lesson.

Shorter lessons, longer lessons and no internet

A 40 to 45 minute lesson

Keep the starter, the explanation and the model at full length: cutting those is what makes the online work fail. Take the time out of the online block and the apply phase. Pupils stop where they are; their progress saves after every answer and reopens at their earliest unfinished question, so the next lesson starts there.

If the internet or the devices are unavailable

Teach from the slides and the worksheet. The slides carry the same teaching as the station walls, and the worksheet carries the key facts, the challenges and the exam practice. Set the online stations when the devices are back.

There is no offline version of the experience, and this plan does not contain one. Do not hand out a printed walkthrough of the stations as a substitute: the experiences are used on the website.

Revise 360 — a product of Revise 360 Ltd, created by Olly Pettitt. An independent resource: not written, endorsed or approved by OCR or any exam board. Classroom use and personal study only.